

Multi-Site Manager (MSM)

DA Official Reference: [Multi-Site Manager](#)

Overview

This document defines how Multi-Site Manager (MSM) is addressed in DA for TFS. It covers how MSM works in DA, how TFS's content hierarchy maps to the DA MSM model, and how each functional requirement is addressed — whether out of the box, through a process change, or through custom development.

1. DA MSM — Current Capability and TFS Collaboration

DA MSM is an actively evolving capability within the DA platform. The Adobe engineering team building DA is continuously expanding MSM to support increasingly complex multi-site requirements.

In its current state, DA MSM supports **one level of inheritance** — a base site rolling out directly to a satellite site. TFS's content hierarchy requires **three levels of inheritance** — Global → Region → Country → Language. To support this, the Adobe DA engineering team will work in direct collaboration with TFS to extend the MSM capability to support TFS's three-level inheritance model. Given TFS's scale — 27 English sites and 13 language alternates across a global hierarchy.

This collaborative engagement means TFS gets direct involvement from the engineering team building the product, with the solution shaped specifically around TFS's real-world hierarchy and authoring needs.

2. How MSM Works in DA

Understanding DA MSM requires a shift in mental model from AEM Sites. The two systems handle inheritance in fundamentally different ways.

AEM Sites — Content Duplication Model

In AEM Sites, when a page is rolled out from a parent to a child site, the content is physically duplicated. Rolling out Global English to North America English creates an identical copy of every page in the North America folder. From that point, authors manage two separate sets of content — the original in Global English and the copies in North America English. Any

inheritance relationship is maintained through MSM sync, but the content itself exists in both places.

DA — File Existence Model

In DA, inheritance is determined entirely by whether a file exists in the satellite site's folder. There is no duplication.

- If a page **does not exist** in the satellite folder — the satellite inherits that page directly from the base site. The page is served to visitors from the base, transparently, at delivery time. No copy sits in the satellite folder.
- If a page **does exist** in the satellite folder — it is treated as a local override. The satellite's version is served instead of the base version.

This means when a base site is rolled out to a satellite, the satellite folder starts completely empty. Authors only see content in the satellite folder when they have explicitly broken inheritance for a specific page. Everything else flows silently from the base.

What This Means for TFS

Today, TFS's MSM setup in AEM creates thousands of page copies across every region and country level. In DA, those copies do not exist by default. Only the pages that TFS has actively localised — where an author has made a region- or country-specific change — will appear in the corresponding DA folder. This is a cleaner, lower-overhead model for content management at TFS's scale.

Two Author Roles in DA MSM

Role	Responsibilities
Base site author	Manages shared content, rolls out changes to satellite sites, cancels or resumes inheritance for specific pages, syncs updates to satellites
Satellite site author	Works on locally overridden pages, syncs updates from base when needed, resumes inheritance to revert a page back to the base

3. TFS Content Hierarchy

TFS organizes content across four levels. The hierarchy flows from a single global content source down through regions, countries, and local language variants.

1	Global English (non-public – master content source)
2	└─ Region English (non-public – e.g. North America, Europe, Latin America)
3	└─ Country English (public – e.g. US English, Brazil English, UK English)
4	└─ Local Language (public – e.g. Brazil Portuguese, French, German)
5	

- **27 English sites** are publicly accessible (country-level English)
- **13 language alternate sites** are publicly accessible (translated local language)
- Global and Regional English are internal — not served to public visitors

This four-level structure maps directly to the DA MSM model as a multi-level base-satellite hierarchy, with Global English as the root base site and each subsequent level acting as both a satellite to its parent and a base to its children.

4. Functional Use Cases — How Each Is Addressed in DA

The following covers each of TFS's functional MSM requirements, how they are met in DA, and what — if anything — changes from today.

Use Case 1 — Multi-Level Content Cascade (Global → Region → Country → Language)

What TFS does today: Content authored at Global English level is cascaded through custom MSM rollout services to Regional English, then Country English, then local language variants. This multi-level cascade is not natively available in AEM Sites — TFS built and maintains a custom service to achieve it.

How it works in DA: Multi-level inheritance is being built into the DA product natively. Once available, the entire cascade — Global through to local language — will work out of the box without any custom development. The product team is actively building this capability, with TFS's use case directly informing the scope.

Status: OOTB — pending DA product delivery of multi-level inheritance

Use Case 2 — Authoring at All Levels and Inheritance Management

What TFS does today: Authors at regional and country levels can create net new pages at their level without starting from global. They can also break MSM inheritance either at the full page level or at an individual component level, allowing localized content while the rest of the page continues to flow from the parent.

How it works in DA:

Creating pages at any level — OOTB Authors can create net new pages at any level of the hierarchy — regional, country, or language — without the page needing to exist at the global level first. This is fully supported.

Breaking page-level inheritance — OOTB Two mechanisms are available:

- A base site author can cancel inheritance for a specific satellite page — the page is then copied into the satellite folder as a local override
- A satellite author can create a page at the same path in their folder — DA treats the presence of that file as an implicit inheritance break

Either way, once the page exists in the satellite folder, it is locally managed from that point onwards. The reverse is also available — authors can use **Resume Inheritance** to delete the local override and revert the page back to inheriting from the base. Inheritance breaks are not permanent.

Breaking block-level inheritance — Process Change

DA does not support breaking inheritance at the block or component level while keeping the rest of the page inherited. This is a process change from AEM Sites.

Process change — how it works in DA: Authors break the inheritance of the full page (as described above). Once the page is a local override, they use the **Sync from Base** action with **Merge** mode — DA shows a content diff of what has changed in the base page versus the local version. Authors review the diff block by block and choose which base changes to accept and which to keep as localised. For the block they want to keep localised (e.g. a regional hero banner), they reject the incoming change. For everything else, they accept it. The result is the same outcome — one block is localised, the rest reflects the parent — but achieved through a sync-and-review step rather than a component-level toggle.

Status: OOTB for page-level and net new pages. Process change for block-level inheritance.

Use Case 3 — Country Fallback / Virtual Sites (e.g. Belgium → UK)

What TFS does today: Countries without their own dedicated site nodes — such as Belgium — are mapped to a primary country through a custom configuration service. Belgium is configured to serve the UK site. No Belgium site is maintained in the content tree; the custom service handles the routing transparently.

How it works in DA: The custom configuration service approach is replaced by a direct rollout. Belgium is rolled out from the Europe region as a satellite site, exactly as any other country would be. Because DA does not duplicate content, the Belgium folder starts empty — no pages are created, no authoring overhead is introduced. Belgium content flows directly from Europe region at delivery time, achieving the same end result as today without a custom routing service.

Process change: Country-to-country inheritance (Belgium inheriting from UK) should be replaced by country inheriting from its region (Belgium inheriting from Europe). This is the recommended content organization pattern in DA — cleaner hierarchy, no custom configuration to maintain.

Status: Process change — rollout from region instead of custom configuration service

Use Case 4 — Custom Recursive Rollout

What TFS does today: TFS maintains a custom MSM rollout service that overrides the AEM OOTB live copy resolution. When a rollout is triggered, this service recursively walks the entire content tree, discovers all direct and indirect live copies, and builds a dependency-ordered rollout queue. Country language variants wait for their country English parent to complete before rolling out.

How it works in DA: This entire customization exists because AEM Sites does not support multi-level inheritance natively. Once DA delivers multi-level inheritance in the product, recursive rollout across all levels is handled automatically. There is no custom service to maintain.

Status: OOTB — with DA multi-level inheritance delivery. Custom service not required.

Use Case 5 — Automatic Path and Link Rewriting During Rollout

What TFS does today: When content is rolled out from Global English to a regional or country node, all internal links and asset path references within the page are automatically rewritten to reflect the target region's path structure. TFS maintains this as a custom capability because AEM Sites does not handle it natively.

How it works in DA: As with recursive rollout, this capability is a natural part of how multi-level inheritance functions in DA. When a page is inherited at a given level, path references resolve correctly for that level's context without manual rewriting or a custom service.

Status: OOTB — with DA multi-level inheritance delivery. Custom service not required.

Use Case 6 — "Other" Nodes (Catch-All for Unmapped Countries)

What TFS does today: Regions maintain "Other" nodes (e.g. Latin America Other, Europe Other) that serve as catch-all destinations for countries not mapped to a specific primary country. These are managed through the same custom configuration service used for country fallback.

How it works in DA: Same approach as Use Case 3. These catch-all groupings are handled by rolling out the relevant countries from their parent region directly. Since DA does not duplicate content, creating these satellite sites has no authoring overhead. The "Other" grouping concept is replaced by regional inheritance.

Status: Process change — same approach as country fallback

Use Case 7 — Activation Cascade (Global → Region → Country)

What TFS does today: When a page is activated at the global level, it triggers activation for all corresponding regional and country nodes sequentially, one by one.

How it works in DA: Publishing in DA MSM cascades to all satellite levels as part of the multi-level inheritance model. A base site author publishing a page pushes it to preview or live environments across all inheriting satellite sites. This is handled natively.

Status: OOTB

Use Case 8 — Custom Relocation (Move with Redirect and Child Pages)

What TFS does today: TFS has a custom relocation function that goes beyond a standard page move. When a page is relocated, all its live copies across regions and countries move with it. The source page is kept in place (not deleted) and configured to redirect to the new location — ensuring bookmarked URLs and external links continue to work. Authors can also include child pages in the relocation.

How it works in DA: This specific relocation behavior — keeping source as a live redirect while copying to the new location across all levels — is not available out of the box in DA. It requires a **custom plugin or app** built using the DA SDK.

Without the customization: When an author relocates a page, they manually add an entry to the redirects spreadsheet (redirects.xlsx) to create the redirect from the old path to the new location. This achieves the same end result for visitors but requires an explicit authoring step rather than an automated action.

With the customization: The relocation action in DA is extended via a custom plugin that automates the redirect creation and handles the cascade across all satellite sites, matching the current behavior.

The custom plugin is an enhancement — the path to EDS is not blocked without it.

Status: Customization required — DA plugin/app. Manual redirect entry available without customization.

Use Case 9 — MSM Visualization (Multi-Level Relationship View)

What TFS does today: TFS maintains a custom interface that visualizes the full MSM relationship tree — direct and indirect live copy relationships, inheritance status, sync flags, and which pages have broken inheritance. AEM's default MSM view only shows first-level relationships.

How it works in DA: A basic MSM relationship view is available out of the box in DA, showing the base-satellite relationships and whether pages are inherited or locally overridden. For TFS's full multi-level visualization — matching the depth and detail of the current custom interface — a **custom plugin or app** can be built using the DA SDK.

Without the customization: The OOTB view provides enough visibility for standard authoring and inheritance management. Authors can identify which pages are overrides and which are inherited.

With the customization: The view is extended to match TFS's current reporting depth, including multi-level relationship tracking and inheritance status across all levels.

Status: Basic view OOTB. Enhanced multi-level view requires custom plugin/app.

5. Summary

Use Case	Status	Notes
Multi-level content cascade (Global → Region → Country → Language)	OOTB — pending product	DA product roadmap. Key dependency for entire MSM solution.
Net new pages at any level	OOTB	Fully supported
Page-level inheritance break and Resume Inheritance	OOTB	Two mechanisms available. Break is reversible.

Block-level inheritance	Process change	Break page-level, then selective sync using Merge mode
Country fallback / virtual sites	Process change	Roll out from region directly — no custom config service
"Other" node catch-all	Process change	Same as country fallback
Recursive rollout across all levels	OOTB — pending product	Comes with multi-level inheritance
Path and link rewriting during rollout	OOTB — pending product	Comes with multi-level inheritance
Activation cascade	OOTB	Publishing cascades to all satellite levels
Custom relocation with redirect	Customisation required	DA plugin/app. Manual redirect fallback available.
MSM visualisation	Basic OOTB / Enhanced customisation	Enhanced view via DA plugin/app